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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58084795.

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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# "You’re such a clumsy idiot" - What If/AU scene

by Cat_and_Kallen

Summary

What if Adora got captured alongside Glimmer when Horde Prime arrived? What would Catra do? What could she do? With the key to the Heart of Etheria in Prime's hand, she does the only thing she can - fulfill a promise.

This was born from a quick discussion on the possibility and quickly turned into a brain bug that must be written. After posting the short version, I wanted to give it a little more attention to see where it led. I'm quite happy with it for the one-shot idea it is. I hope this is a good opening post to grab some attention. I have an ongoing project of hundreds of thousands of words I want to share. Stay tuned.

Feedback, comments, and positive opinions are welcome. Thank you for your time.

Notes

This is a quick story and has a few scene breaks/skips and they are called out specifically.

“Where’s Adora.” Catra snarls.

“What??” Bow squeaks and recoils at the sight.

The rebel camp is recovering after the recent battle and the appearance of Horde Prime's armada over Etheria.

“It’s an easy question, Arrow Boy. The one that turns into a tall shining warrior princess with fancy hair,” Catra pulls at her own mane of hair to make a point. She keeps stomping towards Bow with her eyes lit by fierce determination. “I know you know. You’re all best friends. You all save each other all the time. Where Is She?”

Bow waves his hands in defense of himself. “Please. Catra. I don’t know. But we’re trying to figure that out.”

“Well hurry up. We don’t have all day. Prime could be torturing them right now and you’re just sitting here feeling sorry for yourself.”

“Catra, they are in space! We can’t just run off to find them. It’s going to take time.”

“Where’s tech-princess? She knows all about this sort of stuff. Just make her find Adora.” Catra scours the rebel camp for-

The sound of electricity and mad laughter make it easy.

“You know what, I’ll convince her myself.” Catra turns on her heel and makes a straight line for Entrapta.

Bow rushes to get in front of her. “Catra, No! You can’t hurt Entrapta.” He draws his bow from his back and readies an arrow.

“Why would I hurt her?” Catra’s words fall out of her mouth and her expression scrambles to pick up the pieces. “Never-mind. Just move. I’m not going to hurt anyone. I know my best chance to accomplish something when I see it.”

Bow lets his weapon drop along with his guard. “Does… that mean you’re coming with us?”

“Doi. Now go do whatever it is you princesses do to get ready to pull a win out of thin air. We’re going to need it.”

—
[scene skip. On Darla's bridge]
—

Darla’s intercom crackles to life. The static fades and a voice comes through loud and clear. "Hello?"

“Adora!” Catra runs to the console and slams her hands down “What’s happening. What did you do. Why did you get yourself captured.” she accuses.

“Catra?!”

"Yeah. Who else?"

The sounds of struggle and banging rushes Adora and she sounds panicked. “I don’t have much time.”

Catra's voice is desperate despite her anger “No!" She tries to recover her callous, commanding tone. "No, don’t leave. You stay on this line. We'll figure something out. Don’t do something stupid like you always do. Just this once-“

“I can't pinpoint Darla but I can get close. I’m sending Glimmer to these coordinates, you have to get there in time.”

“Adora. For once just listen to me. What’s going on? What do you mean you’re sending Sparkles? We’re in Space. Dummy.”

“I know. I know. I… I’ve always been dumb… Catra. I am so, so sorry. For everything.” Adora’s words are punctuated by the

sounds of Clones breaking in and attacking her. As they struggle the communication line cuts.

“ADORA!”

—
[scene skip. Prime's station]
—

Horde Prime sits on his throne connected to a number of tubes feeding a sickly green substance into the connections that make up what seems like hair. “Forgive my unseemly state. It is a tedious task, but a necessary one to maintain this vessel.” The chair turns and the clones tending to him back away. Prime stands tall, his towering stature only made more apparent at the top of the stairs. “Poor little Catra… I did not expect to see you here.”

Catra’s eyes are filled with rage and her voice is forced through gritted teeth. “Listen. I’m only going to tell you this once. Give me Adora and I won’t tear you and every clone on this station to pieces.”

“You presume that I fear you. But I do not.” Prime paces with an air of superiority. “I’ve read my faulty brother’s memories, he had little love for you in the end as you fought over such emotional matters. That is not enough for me to fear you or any paltry threats you may make.” He stops and looks down on Catra. “I know all. I see all. There is nothing you can do and I am sure you of all people are well aware of how powerless you really are.”

Catra dons her well earned smug confidence as she replies "And who was the one to take down Hordak? Oh right. Me. You'll be no different. So, either give me Adora or all your little light talk gets snuffed out. Permanently."

Prime puts his hand to his temple. "You tire me with your blatantly false bravado. But if you are so keen on a fight, this might prove entertaining."

"Hey Catra…" the familiar voice is detached and unnatural.

Catra whips around and her tail bushes. She can't believe what she sees before her.

Adora walks up the stairs clad in Horde Prime's whites and grays. The emblem emblazoned on her chest. She pulls back her hood and the ponytail is gone. Replaced by a short ragged haircut that is slicked back, which only adds to the unnatural feeling.

Adora opens her eyes to reveal the green glow of Prime's control.

Catra hisses out of reflex and steps back. "How- How dare you. What have you done to Adora?"

Adora walks past Catra without acknowledging her. She kneels before Prime and bows to him.

Prime smirks. “I have made her anew… I saw her mind.” He offers a hand to Adora and she reaches to take his hand. “So ensnared in gGGAAH!” Prime shouts in pain, staggering back away from Adora. His face twists in anger as he looks at the scratch mark on his arm.

Catra stands defiant next to a bewildered Adora. “Touch her again and see what happens.” Catra growls ominously. Her hackles rise as she bares her fangs and claws to back up her threat.

Adora’s blue eyes flicker in and out as she stares. “Catra?”

“Adora?” Catra inches closer to that familiar voice even though it’s coming from such an infuriatingly twisted embodiment of her best friend.

Prime snarls as all four eyes narrow on the cat. “You really think you can stand against me?” A dark smirk crosses his face as the green glow returns to Adora’s eyes. Prime’s voice is equally dark as he starts again. “You have no bargaining chip, Catra. I control Adora which means I have She-Ra and the heart of Etheria at my fingertips. You and your little rebellion only persist by my generosity.” He snaps his fingers and a loud screech pierces Catra’s ear from the ear-bud.

Catra quickly tears out the device and throws it aside. Her options were dwindling faster and fast-

The monitors behind Prime alight with images from security cameras, all featuring the Rebellion fighters.

Catra's eyes go wide. Her breath catches, she looks to Adora and back to the monitors.

Prime's smirk curls into an arrogant smile. "You miscalculated."

Adora grunts and strains against the control. "Catra… Run."

Prime holds out his hand and motions downward and Adora's fight is crushed out of her. The green glow as steady as her form.

"The last of the First Ones is mine to control. Your rebel insurgents have failed. You have led not only yourself, but everyone to their demise. Though… for you, dear child, that seems to be a recurring theme. Isn't it?" Primes snickers. "Mutual and unstoppable destruction. Why, if you would only see the light I could invite you into my flock. Then, you would be with Your Adora forever." With one hand he motions for Adora to rise and the body acts as instructed.

"Yes. Prime has given me peace. I no longer need my destiny. No longer does my heart ache to be made complete. I've been made

whole. Join me, Catra, and we can have our perfect day together. A perfect life…" Adora walks towards Catra, reaching out a hand towards the cat's cheek.

Catra backs away a step. The blinding light of Prime's ship would never allow a shadow but she could feel one come over her. "No… not like this…"

"Catra please, we can make up for all the time we lost. We can go back to being on the same side again. No one to tear us apart. Only the joy of living together…." Adora is only an inch away from reaching Catra. Her fingertips brush that warm tabby fur. "In Horde Prime's light."

Catra retracts her claws and balls her fist, with a roar she connects with a staggering right hook. The force sends Adora crashing to the ground. Catra turns her unyielding anger towards Prime. "I will Never let you win."

Adora props herself up and rubs at her cheek. Her blue eyes water as the heat rises at the point of impact. "Ow. That really hurt. Catra!" She complains in her old way. Catra snaps to look at her and her eyes soften.

Prime snarls yet again as his pawn acts against his control. "Hmph. Accelerated heart rate. Eye dilation. She means something to you… Very well. Seems you have much to discuss." With a snap of his finger the green glow covers Adora's eyes and the chip sparks with intense electricity.

Adora throws her hand to the chip and her head flies back with a scream of pain.

"Adora?!" Catra whips her attention from Adora to Prime and back. Catra clenches her teeth and without looking she pounces at Prime. Prime only smiles knowingly.

Catra is knocked out of the air as Adora tackles her. They tumble across the platform before Catra can kick Adora away. The two stand in a hurry and square off with each other.

Prime casually walks down the stairs and the clones follow. "I will leave you to it. Whether you make the right decision or not makes no difference to me. I will tend to the pest that now scurry around my ship." Prime exits the throne room and the clones turn to guard the exit.

Catra watches as her prey leaves the room-

Adora snaps a quick jab at the distracted cat who barely gets away in time. "Where are you looking? Aren't I what you truly want?" the chipped Adora sneers.

Catra dances away, light on her feet. "Adora! Why is it the one time I try to do something good you have to make it difficult." Catra lashes out with spinning kicks, forcing Adora to block. "I'm trying here. I know you can see it."

“Too little too late. I tried for three years and look where that go us. You never once took the time to stop and think about US.” Adora weaves in like a boxer, like Lonnie would, and throws a series of jabs again. “But I’m the idiot for trying? Nothing is ever important to you Except You!”

Catra passes each strike and with a quick lunge vaults over Adora to put a kick into her back.

Adora stumbles forward and grips the back of her neck. She rubs the pain out and the chip lightly sparks again. Adora resumes her brawling stance. “Well. Say something. Tell me I’m wrong.” She shouts as she rushes again.

Catra catches the next punch and rolls with it into a joint lock. “And yet I’M HERE-” She pushes Adora to the ground. “FOR YOU!” her voice cracks and the tears blur her vision. “Adora, I’m trying. So please, just stop. I don’t want this.”

Adora’s shoulder wrenches and cracks as she forces out of the hold. Catra feels the vibration and it makes her sick. She lets go immediately and puts distance between her and her opponent.

Adora stands and grunts. With her other hand she pushes the shoulder back into the socket with a roar of pain. She levels her gaze back at Catra and cackles when she sees the look of distress. “Give me a break. You’re only here because Glimmer and Bow were on their way. I bet you were already planning to betray

them. It's all you ever do. You seek power and you take it no matter the means. You even tried to take the power of She-Ra for yourself." Adora smiles in a devilish way "Or do you think I wouldn't remember because of the virus corruption." Adora stalks forward with tense shoulders and her eyes darken. "I should have used that chance to end you and this unbearable friendship."

"Yo-you still see this as a friendship?" Catra blurts, a little bit of hope crossing her face.

"More like a burden-ship. Torment-ship. Disappointment-ship." Adora darts in with a heavy body blow. Even blocking it sends Catra stumbling and gasping for air. "Prime has freed me of all that pain. Now I don't have to worry with you or anyone else. I can be happy as I am."

The hint of light quickly leaves Catra's eyes. "Happy as a tool? As someone else's lap dog? Isn't that what you've been fighting this entire time!? That's nothing like the Adora you were becoming." Catra ducks and dodges again before hand-springing backwards. "Which, I guess I can thank you for. It won't hurt as bad when I knock you out and drag you home." Catra sprints on all fours and leaps into a series of savage strikes. Low kick. Push kick. Jab. Jab.

When Adora blocks her jabs, Catra seizes the moment and traps her guard. With a quick twist she pulls Adora off balance and plants a kick into her midriff. Adora flies back and lands against the throne platform. Her head snaps back and the chip collides with the structure, sparking wildly from the damage.

Adora cackles like mad and grips at her arms. “Even now you think only of yourself. You don’t think about the hurt you cause me. This is why we’re here in the first place. You could never see my pain. You could never see why I had to do what I did.”

“You think I Don’t know! I know exactly why and I HATED IT!” Catra roars. “You’ve always shouldered everything! Shadow Weaver would hurt me but she made that Your Responsibility! I know it hurt you but You Never fought back. Like now. Prime has you under his thumb and you’re just letting it happen! Fight Back Adora! For once, Fight for something YOU Want!” Catra’s face looses all of its light now. “Even if it’s not for me… Even if you really do hate me… Please… Just come back.”

Adora roars with hurt and tackles Catra outright. She lands on the cat and starts to pummel her guard. “I tried to protect you. I tried to help you. I tried so many times! But you always made it harder. You fought me at every turn. At Thaymor. The Crystal castle. The Portal. Every time!” The wild frenzy of blows land again and again.

Catra kicks her hips and throws Adora over-head. She scrambles to her feet and tries to recover. Her head is ringing and her vision darkens on one side. Catra reaches up to try to fix it and grabs the jostled face mask. Pulling it away there’s a moment she looks at the mask and flashes of her reflection in mirrors flood her mind. How she had donned the mask so long ago. Not just the physical one but the emotional one that pairs with it. The growl rumbling in her throat is rough and gravelly. “Fine... I’m done fighting. I’m done fighting for Shadow Weaver! For Hordak! I’m Done Fighting For Etheria. I don’t care anymore!” Catra puts all of her might behind the throw.

Catra’s mask sings as it cuts through the air and buries itself in the monitors. The sparks and explosion drown out everything else in the room.

As the rain of glass settles Catra opens her arms wide. She takes a few careful steps towards Adora. “I’m done fighting for all of those things… But I won't stop fighting for you. I can’t stop Prime. I can’t save the rebellion or Etheria… Not without you, Adora.”

Adora takes a step backwards for every step Catra takes towards her. “What? What are you saying? No-No one can stop Prime. I-I can’t…” her eyes flicker “She-Ra is Gone. Don’t you get it? I’m nothing. I’m nothing without her. No one needs me.”

Catra’s teal and gold eyes fill with tears. “I never needed She-Ra. All I ever needed was Adora. My best friend. Please, you’re all I have- You’re all that I ever had. You meant everything to me… When you left, I didn’t know what to do. All I know was that it hurt too much. I’m sorry I did so many things wrong. I can’t fix any of that… but what I can do is save you this one time. I made a promise and I want to make good on my part of it. I’m going to look out for you.” Catra reaches out her hand to Adora with the warmest, most sincere smile she had ever worn. “So please, Adora, come home.”

Tears.

Tears sparkle and glisten like the millions of stars that came back to the night sky over Etheria. Those beautiful blue eyes shine like

the moons. “I-I hurt you… I hurt you so much… Catra. I’m so sorry. I never meant to.“ Adora reaches out to take her hand-

The green glow snaps back, but this time it’s even more intense with unsettling irises. Prime’s voice layers over Adora’s “Disappointing. Seems I will need to find a new way to access the Heart of Etheria.”

The chips sparks loudly one last time and Adora screams as her foot steps out over nothingness. Her eyes shoot wide and she stretches both arms out to Catra.

— [POV flip] —

Adora feels sick as that weightless feeling turns her stomach upside down. Everything seems to slow down just to draw out that fear of the inevitable. She watches as Catra reacts moment by heart-pounding moment.

Catra drops to all fours and dashes forward. Claws leaving gouges in the pristine white metal floors. Catra leaps up to grab her, tail pinned straight hoping for balance. She's going to make it! Adora feels claws dig into her forearm and pull at her. Catra was right there, so close to her. Almost like the dip at princess prom. But Catra looks so sad. Adora’s heart drops. No…

“You’re such a clumsy idiot.” Catra twists with her lost balance, reversing their positions. Unable to stop, she plants her feet

against Adora and kicks hard.

Adora stumbles back onto the platform and her blood runs cold.

“CATRA!!”

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!